



INDIVIDUAL QUESTIONS – INTRODUCTION

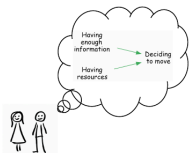
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Because the output is a structured network, we can apply a range of queries to explore the data. This gives us a library of **pre-existing approaches** to ask **practical questions** about the causal landscape described by the participants.

Here's a poster showing a few of the main questions.

Evaluation questions you can answer with causal mapping

Maybe you've heard of causal mapping...



But can you answer useful evaluation questions with it?

Here are a few examples!

What is causal mapping?

Non-causal Qualitative Data Analysis (QDA) version 1: code causality as a thematic approach

Non-causal QDA version 2: code themes/concepts, with explicit causal connections between themes

Causal QDA: code causal claims natively between pairs of codes

We code many "causal claims" across many sources. We use a codebook for cause/effect labels ("factors") which is either predefined or which we develop iteratively. The result is a table of causal links which can be visualised as a map



What is a causal map?

A **causal map** is a diagram in which boxes (which we call factors) are joined by directed links. A link means that someone claimed that one thing influenced or contributed to another.

A **systems map** usually tries to model reality. A **causal map** (or "causal concept map") usually tries to model how stakeholders think about reality. This approach has been used for 50 years (Axelrod, Eden, Ackerman...) in many disciplines, though not so much in evaluation.

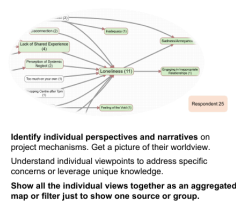
DO use causal mapping when you...

- have many causal claims about links between many causal factors from many different sources
- want to organise all these causal claims
- are interested in differences between sources

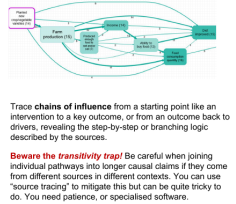
DONT use causal mapping when you...

- are interested in a small number of specific high-stakes causal connections between a small number of causal factors, like the link between "taking the medicine" and "feeling better" (try Process Tracing instead)
- want a mathematical model, e.g. for predicting future states of the system (try Causal Loop Diagramming instead)
- would like to collaboratively develop a model of a problem or a plan for an intervention without worrying too much about who said what (try PFSM instead)

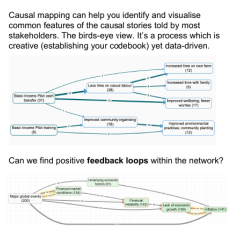
View individual pathways: What is one respondent's experience?



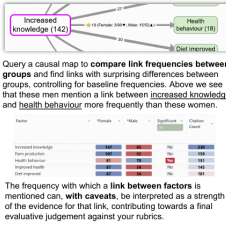
Trace causal chains: What are the direct and indirect consequences of one or more factors?



View aggregated pathways: What is the main story?



Compare groups: Which links were mentioned more by some groups than others?



See also

- **Formatting your map for what you want to show** for the visualisation side.
- **Vignettes** for textual outputs.

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- Individual views – How does the system work according to individual sources ?
- Summarising – How do the sources claim that the system works, in summary ?
- Vignettes – What is a typical source and what is their story ?
- What are the narratives behind a specific link ?
- Which factors and links were most frequently mentioned ?

-  **Which factors and links are mentioned by the most sources ?**
-  **Main outcomes. Which factors are mentioned most often as outcomes ?**
-  **Main drivers. Which factors are mentioned most often as drivers ?**
-  **Splitting by groups. Are different groups involved in different ways ?**
-  **Comparing groups – What factors or links were mentioned more by some groups than others, in the same map ?**
-  **Identifying groups – Are there different subgroups within the data ?**
-  **What are the emerging or unexpected factors ?**
-  **Does the evidence support your theory of change ?**
-  **Assessing systems change**
-  **Sentiment – Which changes are perceived as most positive or negative ?**
-  **Sentiment discrepancy – Which factors do sources most disagree about ?**
-  **Focusing on specific factors. What influences and outcomes are connected to a specific factor ?**
-  **Looking downstream. What are the direct and indirect consequences of one or more factors ?**
-  **Looking upstream. What are the direct and indirect influences on one or more factors ?**
-  **Path tracing – How do one or more causes affect one or more effects, including indirect pathways ?**
-  **Source tracing – What are the consequences of one or more factors, looking only at stories told in their entirety by individual sources ?**
-  **Robustness – How robust is the evidence for that X influences Y ?**
-  **Counting and comparing influences**

 **Properties of the causal map – Which factors are reported as being causally central or causally peripheral ?**

 **Properties of the causal map – What is the overall structure of the network ?**

 **Properties of the causal map – Are there leverage points ?**

 **Properties of the causal map – Are there feedback loops ?**

 **Combining questions**

 **Tribes. The most relevantly different subgroups in your data (by causal story)**

 **Showing group data as custom link labels on the map with optional significance test**

 **Names of tables and fields**

 **Hierarchical coding**
